Osman had embarked on a sudden conquest spree.

There is no written history of his tribe that dates from anywhere near Osman's lifetime; it is not certain that, in the last decade of the thirteenth century, the people of Sogut were even Muslim. But later legends tell of a dream Osman had, of a great tree growing up to shadow the whole world; the Tigris, Euphrates, Nile, and Danube flowed from its roots; beneath its limbs were built scores of cities filled with minarets, where the faithful came to pray; the leaves of the tree were sword blades, and a wind blew against them and pointed them towards Constantinople, which lay in the distance "like a diamond . . . the precious stone of the ring of a vast dominion which embraced the entire world."[1]

And from the beginning of his conquests, it seemed clear that Osman had his eye on Constantinople. He ransacked the nearby countryside, conquered the tribe of the Eskenderum to his north, occupied territory near Ephesus and Pergamum, intruded into Phrygia. The Il-khanate ruler Ghazan, currently occupied with fighting against the Bahri dynasty of Egypt and its tendency to expand, seems to have paid little attention to the agitation just south of the Black Sea. The truth was that Turkish agitation in Asia Minor was nothing new; under Il-khanate supervision, says the contemporary chronicler George Pachymer, the Turks of Asia Minor had been running rampant for decades, laying waste the lands between the coast of the Black Sea and the southern island of Rhodes. Mostly, the Mongol khans ignored the Turks, as long as they stayed where they were supposed to.[2]

But the Emperor Andronicus could not afford to look the other way. When Osman met a Byzantine army at Baphaeum, near Nicaea, and drove them back, Andronicus grew alarmed. He sent his son and co-emperor, the twenty-five-year-old Michael IX, into Asia Minor with a bigger army, but Michael found himself so outnumbered that he retreated without giving battle.

This was an unpleasant case of dejà vu for the empire. Advancing Turks, two hundred years earlier, had launched the First Crusade when a frightened Alexius Comnenus had appealed to the pope for help. Andronicus II did not make the same mistake. Instead of asking for help, he hired it.

The mercenary captain who agreed to come fight the Turks was Roger de Flor, a onetime Knight Templar who had (fortunately for him) been thrown out of the order by Grand Master Jacques de Molay for piracy. He had assembled around him a mercenary crew called the Catalan Company, mostly made up of soldiers from Aragon proper and from the Aragonese-controlled countship known as Catalonia, on the eastern Spanish coast.* He was at loose ends, having just finished up fighting for James of Aragon, and was looking for his next profitable adventure.